What To Give for a Boon?

T.S

A man seriously injures himself and is upset when he realises that he will never be able to play sport again. That is, until he meets a being that offers the impossible, and for such a minor price.

Gray laughed as he faked left to spin past the defender, his shoulder dropping at just the right moment to disguise his intention.

Should have been looking at his feet! They always told the truth. Gray moved like the wind towards goal, the keeper racing forward to try and intercept him.

Pitiful.

Gray stepped over the ball once, twice, thrice. He was teasing the opponent.

He always made them think they had a chance, before sweeping the rug up underneath them and slotting it into the back of the net.

Gray danced past the keeper and planted his left foot onto the ground, getting ready to shoot.

In that split second, alarm bells rang in his head. Gray had taken too much time; a defender had managed to sprint up behind him. Gray went to brace, but it was too late, contact was made. The defender crunched into his shoulder and Gray went over, his knee buckling under his weight.

As he went down, he heard an audible ‘pop’.

That was when he began screaming.

He lay on the green turf, howling as red-hot pain laced through his leg.

“Holy shit, you alright?” The defender had a stricken look on his face.

“No. Fuck. Oh fuck, get me off please.” Gray moaned.

“It might not be best to move …”

“Someone get me the fuck off the pitch!” Gray bellowed. Two people let him put his arms around their shoulders and he hobbled off, convulsing with every step.

The pain was horrible. But it wasn’t what made the tears roll down Gray’s face. What made him howl at the world.

It wasn’t the first time this had happened. It had to be an ACL. Also know as thousands of dollars and a year or more of rehab.

Gray tried to ignore the thought that was squirming in his head. At how it wasn’t a thought, but a truth. He had had too many reconstructions already.

There was every chance that he would never play again.

His opponents managed to drag him to the sidelines.

“How do you want … where can we leave you?”

“Just drop me man.”

After hesitating, they let go, allowing Gray to fall on his behind.

“Is there anything we can do?”

Gray looked at them for a second. They saw the wetness on his cheeks and were looking incredibly uncomfortable, not knowing what to say. Luckily they were interrupted.

“And that’s game!” A voice called out along with a piercing whistle.

Gray shook his head, breathing out deeply. He had seriously injured himself thirty seconds before the session ended. You couldn’t make it up.

Gray continued to hold his knee, as well-wishers went up to him, asking how they could help, what did he need. He thanked them and sent them on their way, trying to put on a brave face.

There was nothing anyone could do.

He drove home sobbing, as fire stabbed through his knee with every brake and acceleration.

Maybe he got lucky? Maybe it wasn’t as seriously damaged as he thought?

The knee turning purple somewhat eroded the fantasy.

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Gray sat on the knee-height grey wall that separated the cement walkway from the sand. It was raining, the downpour filled with cold, heavy droplets that had drenched his hair and jumper.

The waves crashed with vigour, brown water cresting with froth. The anger in the sea perfectly reflected Gray's mental state.

The surgeon had shaken his head with sadness when Gray had limped into his office.

The scans had not been good.

He had torn his graft. Again. They had already taken tendons from both hamstrings to fix it. If he decided to have surgery, it would be Gray's fourth operation. And the risk of tearing it again only got higher.

"Now Gray, there are active, and what we call *relaxed* lifestyles. Maybe it is time to start asking yourself what would be best for you. And I know it can be a hard question, and I am sorry to say this but … sometimes it's the body, not the brain, that is telling you the answer."

The words had stayed with him long after the consultation. Maybe … no not maybe.

Definitely. It was over. He had to give football up. The thought made the bottom of his stomach thicken, and his throat filled with sadness.

"I don't want too…" Gray whispered into the wind. Childish words. What's done is done.

But he couldn't accept it. It meant giving up a hobby, a lifestyle, that made him who he was as a person.

Was it what made him who he was?

The inner conflict made him scream into the rain. He wanted, needed, to get rid of the raw emotion flowing through him.

"I will do *anything* to have my knee back!"

The outrage made him feel good for a second. It disappeared when his knee began throbbing.

Gray dropped his head into his hands.

He breathed in and out, trying to collect himself. He was upset. Depressed.

A big loss does that. That did not make his life worthless. He would overcome this.

Right?

He swallowed bile and lifted up his head.

To gasp.

The weather had just … stopped. In front of him were the rain pellets, frozen in time. When he lifted a finger and touched one, it wobbled, but stayed in place. He looked from side to side. In the distance, it seemed that the rain was still pouring, it was just his corridor of the beach that was at a stand-still.

The beach!

The waves were also suspended, some in the middle of crashing.

As he watched, paralysed, Gray saw a shadow. Out of the ocean, slithered a figure.

Gray rubbed his eyes as it got closer.

It was not of this Earth.

From the bottom, was a snake-like tail, the scales glittering brown and gold. It had a shark head; its maw filled with teeth underneath beady black eyes.

Yet these weren't its most peculiar features. Its chest was wooden, planks of oiled timber meshing symmetrically between the top and bottom of the creature. A white cloth blew behind its back like a fin. Gray thought it was a cloak, until it got closer, whereby he could see that the cloth was upheld on yardarm.

Once it had made its way up the beach, it stopped in front of Gray.

"Um. Hello?" He stammered.

The Shark's sharp teeth shone.

"We all wish for this and that.

For impossibilities and for very real probabilities. Why act so surprised when what you yearn for appears in front of you?" Its voice was deep and masculine, the edges of each word frayed.

"I'm sorry?"

"Foolish man. You have come to the sea and asked for life. For dreams. For a past to become your future. I am here to deliver."

Gray blinked.

"Are you talking about my knee?"

"A miracle! The man has become a seer." A deep wheeze came out of the Shark, the wooden planks contracting and expanding.

"Wait a second." Gray replied.

"Are you trying to say that you can fix my knee?"

"You have asked for a boon. It can be done."

A flood of emotion streamed through Gray's heart. Could he … be fixed?

Gray had never believed in the fantastical.

He would happily recant when confronted by the impossible's razor teeth.

"Yes. Fix me."

"It can be done. For a price." The being wheezed again, the rolling sound synonymous with the crash of waves.

Was it … laughing? Gray's good feeling dissipated.

"What price?"

"To make the impossible is no easy feat. It can be done, but there must be payment. What is no longer there must be replaced and therefore taken. Your lost time can be given but must be forfeited by someone else."

"Are you saying that you are going to take someone else's knee?"

"Someone's knee, someone's leg, someone's life … it is all material.

Certainly, *something* will be taken."

Gray thought hard. He could save himself. All this pain and suffering, the knowledge that the future would be devoid of the sport he loved. All gone with the snap of the fingers.

Or more like, the slap of a serpent's tail.

Sure, someone got punished and didn't deserve it. Feeling the throb in the back of his knee, Gray reminded himself that he didn't deserve it either. No-one deserved any misfortune, not really.

Did that stop pain and suffering from afflicting some of the most kind-natured people?

This world, his life, was built on the broken backs of millions of people he would never see, hear or feel for. He just enjoyed the fruits of their labours, when he went to any superstore, and bought toys, clothes and condiments made in a place he wouldn't be able to understand.

What difference did one more horror make?

"Do it." Gray said.

"I beg your pardon?" The Shark replied slyly.

"I said fucking do it. Give me back my knee."

"Of course. Yet I must mention one more thing. My brethren gloat over the misguidance of what our wish takers *sac*, yet it is important that I make it clear.

You see, it is not just the *sac* that I relish, but the wilful *sac*. That is what rings golden in my ears."

Gray frowned.

"The *sac*?"

"Yes. You may know it as a 'sacrifice'. Be aware that the person you *sac*, will be someone you know. See, your boon must be taken from someone who has shared your lifeforce. To fix you, to grant your wish, a *sac* must be made from your life."

Gray's head swam. He had to hurt someone close to him? His family, girlfriend, friends, someone?

“Who?”

“A boon must be secured before judgement is confirmed.”

Gray looked at his leg. He would never play again.

The knowledge made him sick to his stomach. Yet now, some … monster was offering him everything he wanted.

“And for such a *small* price.” It finished the thought in his head.

Was it a genie?

Or a monster?

“No.” He shook his head. “I’m not doing that.”

“Of course. The boon has been declined. The price is too high. But before departure, I would ask you listen for just a little bit longer.

Please consider what the *sac* means.

Taste the word, swirl it around your mouth.

What makes a leader great is the knowledge that to achieve victory, a sacrifice must be made. Wars have turned, because one man’s love is not above the needs of a nation. Political prosperity, in the government, the office and the community, involves the *sac* of morals and partners. Success and *sac* can be homogenous.

To sac everything is madness, yet, many have only reached prestige because of what they have relinquished. It is art. It is learning. It is sometimes the only path towards greatness.

So, I ask again.

To a man who has requested an impossible boon and now it has been delivered to him.

Will you pay the price?”

Gray stared in thought.

He whispered something softly.

The Shark wheezed and turned, slithering back to the water. When it disappeared, the waves began moving again, and the rain crashed back into Gray.

He turned and hopped back to his car.

The drive home was quite dangerous, instead of looking at the road, for some reason, Gray was constantly staring down at his legs.

When he woke up the next day, his girlfriend, Jackie, yelled in happiness. The swelling in his knee had completely reduced. Not only that, but somehow, the scar marks where the surgeons had operated in the past had also disappeared.

Jackie asked him questions, but Gray was unable to answer, he was too busy jumping around in excitement. He felt no pain and could twist back and forth.

The elation touched both of them, causing them to consummate, both breathless with shock at how different their moods had been less than twelve hours ago.

Gray went to work, and once he was finished, he headed to training, a beautiful night that left him sweaty but satisfied.

He was back in business!

His team couldn't believe that he had returned, remarking on his miraculous recovery. Many asked probing questions, but Gray just shook his head, saying that he had somehow gotten lucky, and the scans hadn't been as bad as he had originally thought.

Gray drove home giddy. It was as if a massive weight had lifted off his shoulders. He could still play sport! What made him who he was, still existed in his life.

The phone call arrived in the middle of the night.

His mum could barely squeeze the words out over her tears.

His oldest friend, Peter, from his hometown, had been in a tragic car accident.

Peter had completely destroyed his legs and the bottom of his spinal cord, the limbs crushed into the floor of the car. A piece of shrapnel had also sheared off a part of his temple, causing significant brain damage. The doctors hadn't said much, the good news being that Peter wouldn't die.

He was still in a coma, but if he woke, it was likely that he would be in a hospital bed for the rest of his life.

Gray said all the right words to his heartbroken mother, and when polite to do so, hung up the phone. He stared into the darkness and then went back to bed.

Gray imagined he heard the creature wheezing next to his ear.

“A boon has been completed.”

A horrible, horrible price. It made Gray feel terrible.

Although at least it wasn’t one of his best friends or family members. And looking at his crappy apartment, a dark thought squirmed into his brain.

How many more boons could be offered?

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When Gray woke up the next day, he was disgusted by his selfish thought. What happened to Peter would *not* happen again. It filled him with guilt.

Unfortunately, as the days passed, his shame began to fade. Especially when he could run around on the pitch. The exercise really helped his mental well-being.

That’s when Juliet got the promotion instead of Gray. He sat behind his computer, teeth clenched in the Teams meeting while his boss made the announcement. It was some kind of sick joke right? Gray had toiled hard to show his worth, and he was overlooked like that?

He came home with pent up rage, and told Jackie about it, expecting her to agree about how unfair it all was.

What she said shocked him. That maybe this Juliet did deserve it, and maybe he wouldn’t have been overlooked if he tried harder at the office.

He yelled at her, and after some heated exchanges, threw the forbidden B-word at her in fury.

Gray had seen the flash of shock on her face when he said it. He had crossed a line. A big one.

Gray left before he could cause any more damage.

Flush with anger and guilt, he drove around aimlessly.

It didn’t take long for him to arrive at the beach.

It was warm this time, the sun about to set in the late afternoon. People in trunks and bikinis milled around the carpark.

Gray sat still, hands white as they gripped the steering wheel. Mechanically, he exited the car, walked down to the sand and stood in position between the people lazing in the sunshine.

He sighed. Should he really do this?

Wrestling with his thoughts, Gray waited for time to stand still.

His wish was answered.

“Another boon is requested?” The Shark lifted its head next to Gray’s, its breath hot and slimy.

“Yes.”

“What, dear man, would you like to have bequeathed?”

“Any chance you do two for the price of one?”

The creature wheezed, its nostrils expanding in its laughter.

“You come with high expectations. They can be satisfied. As long as the appropriate … *sacs* … are made.” Its voice was silky around the word.

“Whatever. I just want my promotion. And to never fight with my girlfriend again. Can you do that?”

“It will be done.”

Gray came back home to Jackie apologising profusely. They made up, their relationship stronger than ever.

Although, over the next few days, Gray noticed that Jackie didn’t say much, if anything at all, outside his presence.

When he was talking to her, she would laugh, smile and make sure he had everything he needed. But when he left the house, or when he went to a different room without her, Jackie wouldn’t do anything by herself.

She would remain wherever their conversation left her, staring blankly at nothing. Jackie wouldn't even leave the house, only if Gray asked her to go get something.

It was weird. Yet Gray deliberately ignored it. At least Jackie did everything he asked and never got upset anymore.

At work however, there was a horrible accident. The elevator had a major malfunction, falling from fifty stories to explode on the ground floor. Multiple people from different companies had been killed, including Gray's boss.

It led to a re-structuring of his department, and Gray ended up receiving his promotion.

A move only possible because Juliet became the senior manager, taking up the now vacant position.

It irked Gray.

Luckily, he had some ideas on how to fix that.

Over the course of the year, Gray went through a sweeping amount of changes. He moved to a much nicer apartment with a new girlfriend, a tall blonde skimp of a thing.

Most importantly, his career path changed. In a remarkable turn of events, Gray became a professional footballer. Picked up by some scouts and given a chance in the big-time, Gray played exceptionally. It baffled experts, no footballer had turned shined so brightly on the big stage with no prior experience or academy training. Gray's story, and success on the pitch, drew him a growing fan base. With the fame came overseas trips, ridiculous parties, and designer clothes that clung to his figure. Those who knew him even asked if he had somehow grown a couple inches taller.

That was, if there were many of them left.

The success dazzled Gray. Although not quite enough for him to ignore the misfortunes that were becoming more and more common to the people he had grown up with.

When officers of the law looked into it, the different ways everyone met their fate suggested that there was no foul play.

There was only one clear connection.

All these people had a relationship with Gray.

Some had accidents. Friends, acquaintances and distant family members died from plane crashes, workplace malfunctions and sporting mishaps. Others had psychological breakdowns, more than one was sent to the psychiatric ward despite no history of chronic disorders in their family line.

Gray was far too busy to hear about most of the incidents, but when he did, he tried to do everything in his power to help the individual or their family. He sent money and when possible, he visited, offering his thoughts and prayers.

He stopped doing it when those grieving received him and then had a tragic accident themselves.

One of his best friends, John, left the oven on in his apartment, resulting in a disastrous housefire that not only claimed the lives of him and his wife, but also their unborn child. The blaze tore through most of their apartment complex, leaving over fifteen households homeless.

John's parents, now childless, were soon hounded by the insurance companies' debt collectors for repayments going towards the entire complex had been destroyed.

His sixty-five-year-old parents were forced to sell their house, liquidating all assets, leaving them on the streets penniless.

Gray had rushed out to find them when it came to his attention. His face was stone when he watched their bodies be loaded onto the ambulance.

They had frozen to death out on the streets, just a few hundred metres from the soup kitchen.

That, along with all the other tragedies, made Gray question what he was doing. What he had sacrificed for his success.

The guilt threatened to overwhelm him. It consumed him when he received the call from the hospital.

Gray had inadvertently *sacced* his family.

At the same time of one of the biggest games of his football career, his sister Mary had her graduation. Unbeknownst to her, one of her peers put a bunch of

texts on full display in front of the large audience, which exposed her drug addiction.

It later turned out to be lies, but the damage was done. The school pre-emptively expelled her, her parents and friends belittled her for her transgressions.

It didn't take long for Mary to think there was no other way out. The gun was in her mouth when their mother, Jo, walked into her bedroom.

The bullet that ended Mary's life tore into Jo, slicing through the ligaments and tendons in her neck. The surgeons managed to save her, but Jo was paralysed from the head down, forced to live with a permanent reminder of what she had lost.

Gray's father broke down when he told his son the news. Gray himself sat with blank eyes.

His phone buzzed with love from social media. When he looked down, he saw thousands of messages wishing their condolences.

Messages he had bought with the darkest of currency. Not one was from someone he actually knew. Someone had had grown up with. Who he cherished his relationship with.

Those people were all gone.

There was no-one left. Gray started crying, ugly sobs. Until he realised.

Jackie. His ex. She was still alive.

Someone could still be there for him! Gray texted her in the hospital. He went to look at his mother when his phone shook. Jackie had already replied!

When he asked to meet up, he was surprised when she sent him the address to their old apartment. No matter, at least he knew where to go.

It was a dark stormy night when he arrived. The complex had always been a little seedy, but the peeling walls, rubbish stacked in the corridor and cracked windows was a plunge into decay.

Stepping around a sleeping bum on the staircase, Gray knocked on their door. It opened at the force. Their apartment looked the same as the day he had left.

Except for the excessive dust, lack of light and reek of mould. This is what Jackie was living in?

“Hello?”

“Oh honey! Come in!”

He walked into the living room. There in the corner, facing the wall, standing still, was Jackie.

“Jackie?” He whispered.

She turned.

“Gray! You’re home honey!”

The sweet sound of her voice did nothing to drown out the repulsion Gray felt.

Jackie’s face was sunken and haggard. When she smiled, he saw purple, toothless gums, blood and pus leaking out. One of her arms was bent and battered, the fingernails black. Dirt layered her whole body, the dress she wore covered in stains.

“Jackie?” Gray repeated in shock.

She stepped towards him.

“I will do anything for you Gray. How can I help?”

Gray let out a scream and ran. He charged down the staircase and out the building.

Jackie simply turned and stared at the wall.

Gray stepped onto the beach. He let out a moan when the waves stopped, despite having seen it many times before. The creature waded out of the waves.

“Another boon, and one so quickly. What do you require?”

Gray swallowed.

“I want to go back.”

The Shark wheezed.

“Go back?” It repeated.

“Yes. Back to the start. When I had family, friends … girlfriends. My boon is to go back before I met you.”

The creature moved around Gray, it’s white cloth fin flagging behind.

“You do not understand. A boon is a treasure. It cannot be re-buried if it is spent.

There is no going back.”

Gray felt fear crawl up his spine. He stomped his foot in the sand.

“You have magically made anything I asked for. What the fuck do you mean you can’t go back?”

“Because of the *sac*. You cannot *sac* something while you hold the belief that it can be undone. It removes the gravity of the choice.”

“Please. I didn’t realise … I didn’t mean to … I will do *anything* to get them back.”

“A similar phrase was said when a man’s knee was in pain.

Boons are not and life is not easy. Best of luck, I will return when you need something to be bequeathed.”

The creature turned.

“Wait!”

It looked back at him.

“I wish … I wish …” Gray stammered and then resolved.

“I wish to die. I cannot live with the pain I have caused.”

The Shark’s black eyes stared at him.

“Your boon is to end it all? To find rest in the eternal nothingness?”

“Yes.”

The wheezing returned. It was louder than it had ever been.

“Don’t laugh at me!”

The wheezing somehow exacerbated.

The serpent tail expanded on the sand, as well as the wooden torso. The shark head opened its mouth and extended over Gray's body. Suddenly, he was inside, the razor teeth buzz-sawing around him.

A voice echoed around through the gums.

"You now have true understanding. A *sac* is not a choice made lightly.

To *sac* it all is madness. You are gifted one final boon."

Gray swallowed.

"Yes. Please. Kill me."

"Penance." The Shark cried. The teeth came together and Gray screamed as he was chewed up. But … there was no pain.

Sunlight returned as he was spat back onto the sand. Time was moving. There was no sign of the Shark.

He went back to his car. And realised.

Gray couldn't feel anything. His hands, feet, tongue. Couldn't taste or touch. It didn't take him long to get his hands on a pistol. The bullet bounced off his skull, off his throat.

He held his head underwater and screamed bubbles after ten minutes.

Gray howled in frustration. In realisation.

He cried. No tears came out. It seemed he had lost the ability to do that to.

Gray sat down and put his head in his hands.

Wait.

What was that?

Was that what he thought it was?

A deep, thick wheezing in his ear.

The End